

Passages - Twilight of the Idols

As a dialectician a man has a merciless instrument to wield; he can play the tyrant with it: he compromises when he conquers with it. The dialectician leaves it to his opponent to prove that he is no idiot: he infuriates, he likewise paralyzes. The dialectician cripples the intellect of his opponent.

'reason at any price'? - It is a piece of self-deception on the part of philosophers and moralists to suppose that they can extricate themselves from degeneration by merely waging war upon it. They cannot thus extricate themselves: that which they choose as a means, as the road to salvation, is in itself again only an expression of degeneration - they only modify its mode of manifesting itself: they do not abolish it. Socrates was a misunderstanding. The whole of the morality of amelioration - that of Christianity as well - was a misunderstanding. The most blinding light of day: reason at any price; life made clear, cold, cautious, conscious, without instincts, opposed to the instincts, was in itself only a disease, another kind of disease - and by no means a return to 'virtue', to 'health', and to happiness. To be obliged to fight the instincts - this is the formula of degeneration: as long as life is in the ascending line, happiness is the same as instinct.

"Reason' in language! - oh what a deceptive old witch it has been! I fear we shall never be rid of God, so long as we still believe in grammar.

To annihilate the passions and desires,

simply on account of their stupidity, and to obviate the unpleasant consequences of their Stupidity, seems to us today merely an aggravated form of stupidity

To attack the passions at their roots means attacking life itself at its source: the method of the Church is hostile to life.

The same means, castration and extirpation, are instinctively chosen for waging war against a passion, by those who are too weak of will, too degenerate, to impose some sort of moderation upon it; by those natures who, to speak in metaphor (and without metaphor), need la Trappe, or some kind of ultimatum of war, a gulf set between themselves and a passion. Only degenerates find radical methods indispensable: weakness of will, or more strictly speaking, the inability not to react to a stimulus, is in itself simply another form of degeneracy. Radical and mortal hostility to sensuality, remains a suspicious symptom: it justifies one in being suspicious of the general state of one who goes to such extremes.

The man who has renounced war has renounced a grand life.

We immoralists, on the contrary, have opened our ears wide to all kinds of comprehension, understanding and approbation." We do not deny readily, we glory in saying yea to things.

Our eyes have opened ever wider and wider to that economy which still employs and knows how to use to its own advantage all that which the sacred craziness of priests and the morbid reason in priests rejects; to that economy in the law of life which draws its own advantage even out of the repulsive race of bigots,

the priests and the virtuous - what advantage? But we ourselves, we immoralists, are the reply to this question.

Everything valuable is consequently easy, necessary, free. Exertion is god is characteristically different from the hero (light feet are the first attribute of divinity).

The first preparatory schooling of intellectuality. One must not respond immediately to a stimulus; one must acquire a command of the obstructing and isolating instincts. All lack of intellectuality, all vulgarity, arises out of the inability to resist a stimulus: one must respond or react, every impulse is indulged

Greek philosophy is the decadence of the Greek instinct: Thucydides is the great summing up, the final manifestation of that strong, severe positivism which lay in the instincts of the ancient Hellene. After all, it is courage in the face of reality that distinguishes such natures as Thucydides from Plato: Plato is a coward in the face of reality - consequently he takes refuge in the ideal: Thucydides is master of himself - consequently he is able to master life.

Ecstasy: In this state a man enriches everything from out his own abundance: what he sees, what he wills, he sees distended, compressed, strong, overladen with power. He transfigures things until they reflect his power - until they are stamped with his perfection. This compulsion to transfigure into the beautiful is - Art. Everything-even that which he is not - is nevertheless to such a man a means of rejoicing over himself

The highest sensation of power and security finds expression in grandeur of

style. That power which no longer requires to be proved, which scorns to please; which responds only with difficulty; which feels no witnesses around it; which is oblivious of the fact that it is being opposed; which relies on itself fatalistically, and is a law among laws: - such power expresses itself quite naturally in grandeur of style.

Whenever man's spirits are downcast, it is a sign that he scents the proximity of something 'ugly.

We no longer value ourselves sufficiently highly when we communicate our soul's content. Our real experiences are not at all garrulous.

Those things for which we find words are things we have already overcome. In all speech there lies an element of contempt. Speech, it would seem, was only invented for average, mediocre and communicable things. - Every spoken word proclaims the speaker vulgarised.

The free man is a warrior.

Great sacrifices must have been made on the altar of good taste, for its sake many things must have been done, and much must have been left undone. The first rule of all: nobody must 'let himself go', not even when he is alone. - Good things are exceedingly costly; and in all cases the law obtains that he who possesses them is a different person from him who is acquiring them. Everything good is an inheritance: that which is not inherited is imperfect, it is simply a beginning.

But great men are misunderstood when they are regarded from the wretched standpoint of public utility.